pointing out that our success on Cuba does not prove that force can solve everything," wrote Schlesinger.[20]

Both Kennedy and Khrushchev claimed to have prevailed in the crisis. But if Kennedy was concerned about how to secure and make use of his victory, Khrushchev was more preoccupied with explaining his sudden changes of position and apparent capitulation on the issue of Turkey. He committed himself to fight that battle with one hand only; the second was busy concealing the "gift" that Kennedy had offered him—the Cuba-Turkey swap. Whatever he said to others and others told him, subsequent events showed that Khrushchev had dramatically changed his attitude toward Kennedy. The young president whom he had considered inexperienced and weak grew in his eyes into a formidable figure who could not be pushed around and had to be reckoned with. Khrushchev learned to respect Kennedy.

One leader who refused to claim victory was Fidel Castro. If one listened to Khrushchev, then Castro had benefited most from the deal that the Soviet leader had made with Kennedy, putting his own prestige and the security of his state on the line. Cuba had avoided not only American attack and occupation but almost certain annihilation in a nuclear conflict, and Castro's regime had received an American pledge of noninvasion. But Castro felt differently. He considered himself to have been robbed not only of the missiles and nuclear warheads that he already had on the island but also, and more importantly, of his dignity as head of an independent country. And he was not prepared to sacrifice his prestige on the altar of his newfound communist religion.